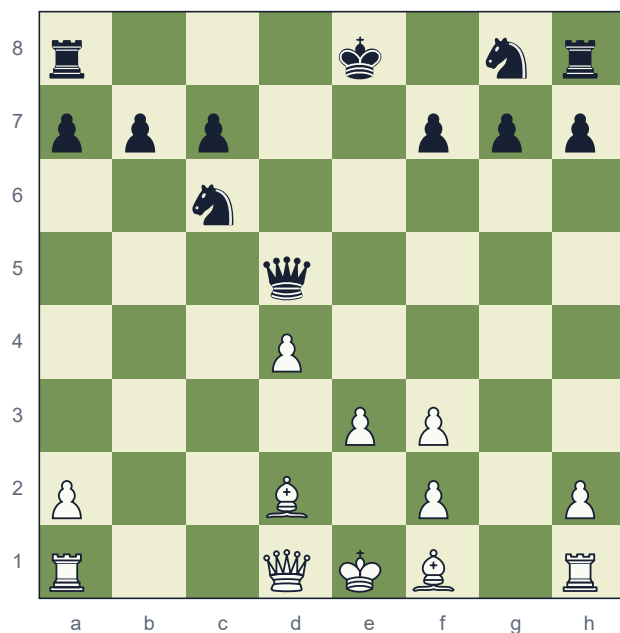


The Chigorin Defense

1.d4 d5 2.c4 Nc6 3.Nf3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Use central exchanges to question the early c6 knight. The main choice accepts doubled pawns after ...Bxf3 in return for the bishop pair and central control; this requires concrete attention to king safety.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The knight on c6 blocks Black's c-pawn. Black compensates with ...e5 and piece activity. White may obtain the bishop pair or a strong center, but cannot ignore tactical pins.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black uses ...Bg4, ...e5 and sometimes ...dxc4. A bishop capture on f3 can alter your pawn structure before you castle.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. The absence of ...c5 does not mean Black lacks a central break: watch ...e5.
2. A doubled pawn can be acceptable if it supports a strong center and the king stays safe.
3. Do not attempt to win the d5 pawn without checking the e1 king and queen checks.

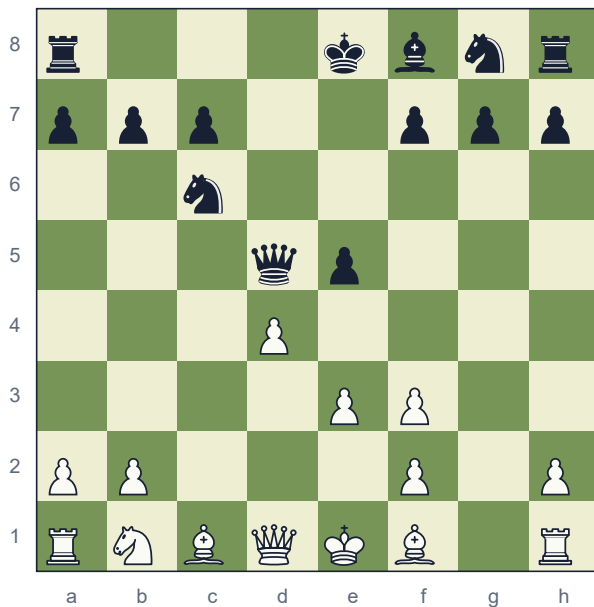
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Main reply: exchange and accept the structural trade

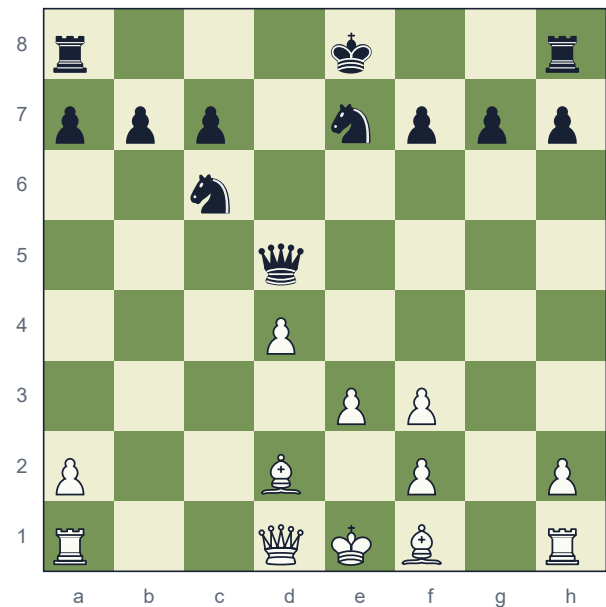
STUDY LINE 09-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. gxf3 Qxd5 6. e3 e5 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd2 Bxc3 9. bxc3 exd4 10. cxd4 Nge7

Selected anchor ends with 10. cxd4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black gives up bishops to damage your pawns. White accepts a broad center and the bishop pair; e3 supports development and the d4 square.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the f1 bishop and secure the king according to the open lines. The central pawns can restrict the knights, but must remain supported.

WATCH FOR

This structure is not a normal QGD. The g-file is open and the f-pawns are doubled; reassess king safety rather than castling by reflex.

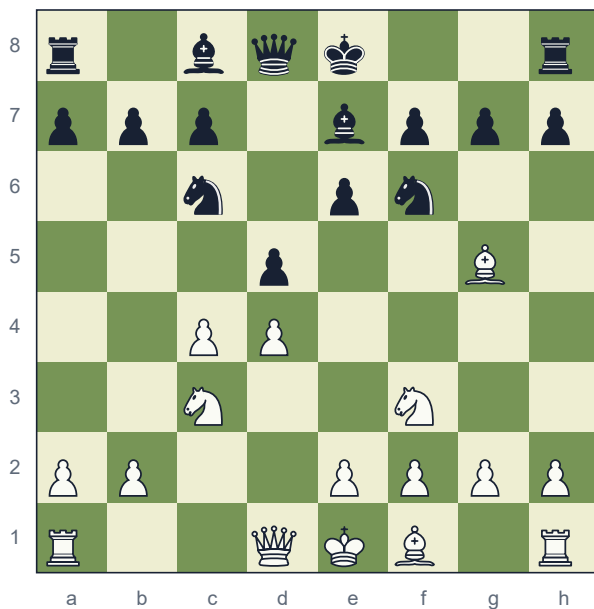
REMEMBER The bishop pair and center can justify doubled pawns.

02 Black develops ...Nf6

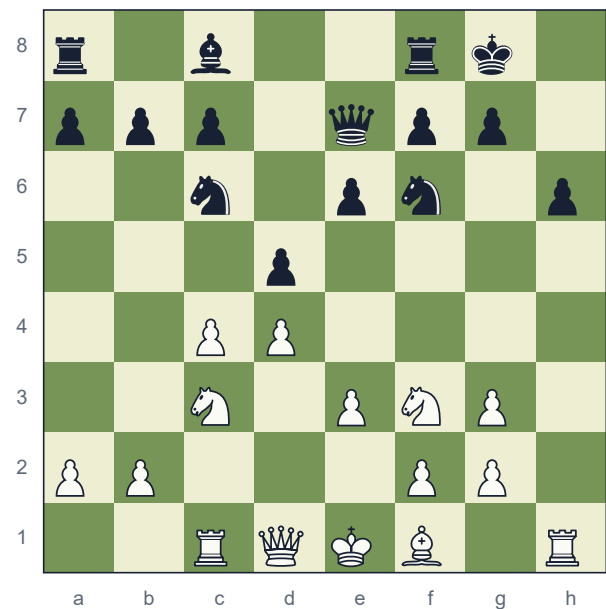
STUDY LINE 09-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Rc1 h6 8. Bf4 Bd6 9. Bg3 Bxg3 10. hxg3 Qe7

Selected anchor ends with 6... O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black has chosen a solid setup with the c-pawn blocked. Ordinary development gives you a comfortable central position.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bd3 and castling come first. A later cxd5 may lead to a structure where Black needs ...e5 to free the position.

WATCH FOR

Do not exchange automatically if keeping the tension restricts Black more effectively.

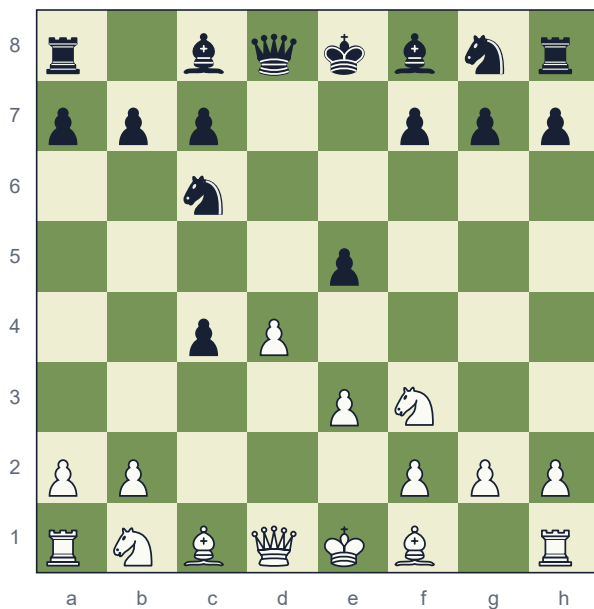
REMEMBER Keep the useful tension until an exchange improves your pieces.

03 Black captures the c-pawn

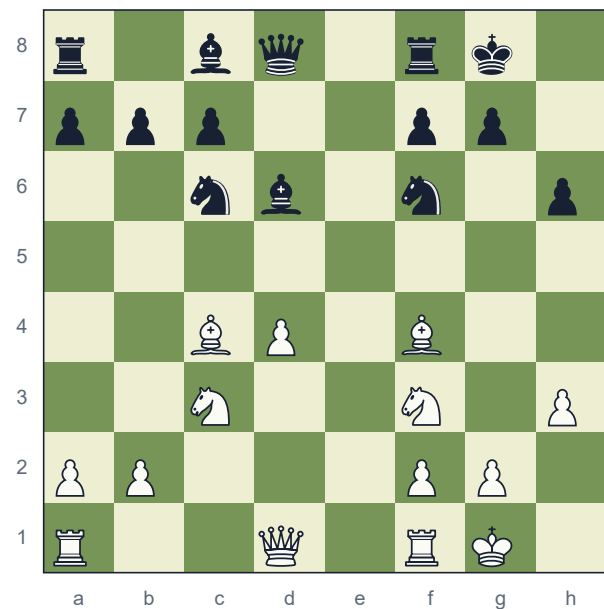
STUDY LINE 09-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 dxc4 4. e3 e5 5. Bxc4 Bb4+ 6. Nc3 exd4 7. exd4 Nf6 8. O-O O-O 9. h3 h6 10. Bf4 Bd6

Selected anchor ends with 5. Bxc4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Recover with the bishop while accepting that Black can build an e5 center. You should compare central control, not just the opening label.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Castle and use Nc3 to increase pressure on the center. Calculate d5 only when it gains something concrete.

WATCH FOR

A premature d5 may surrender key squares and help Black's knights.

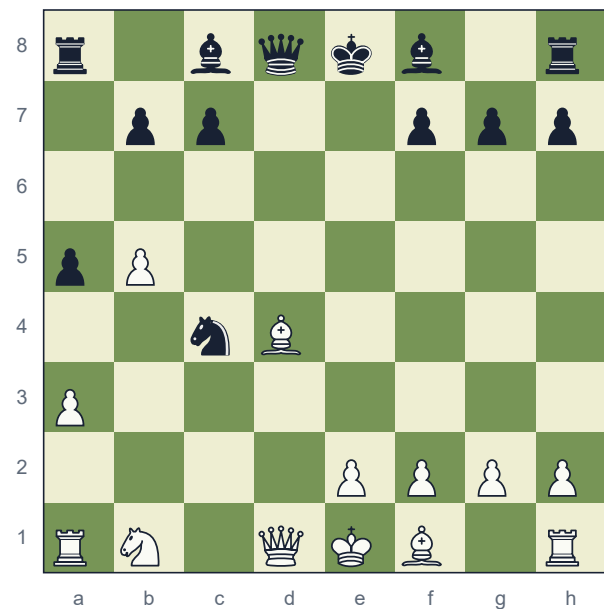
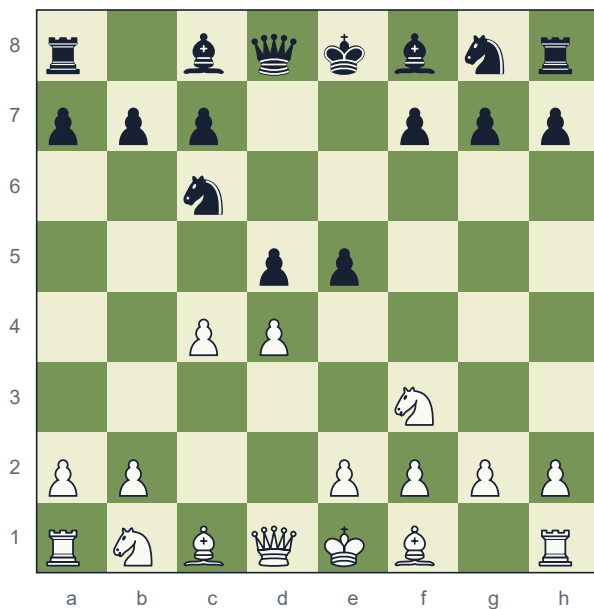
REMEMBER Get the pieces out before driving the center forward.

04 Early ...e5 in the center

STUDY LINE 09-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 e5 4. dxe5 d4 5. a3 Nge7 6. b4 Ng6 7. Bb2 a5 8. b5 Ncxe5 9. Nxe5 Nxe5 10. Bxd4 Nxc4

Selected anchor ends with 4... d4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



WHY THESE MOVES

This resembles the Albin but has a different move order. The pawn wedge still deserves attention, and Nbd2 is a useful developing idea.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

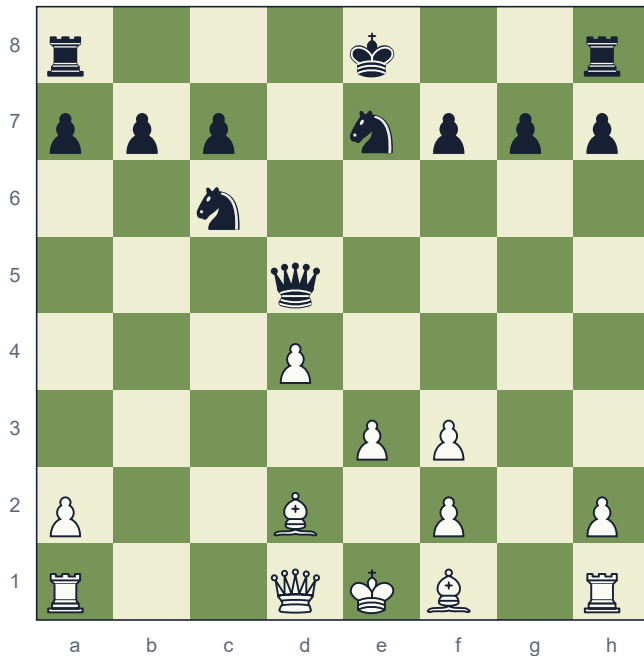
Use the Albin booklet as a structural guide, while checking the exact position and whether every transposition really matches.

WATCH FOR

The same pawn structure can occur with a different side to move. Never add a free tempo when memorizing a transposition.

REMEMBER Recognize the wedge; verify the tempo.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The knight on c6 blocks Black's c-pawn. Black compensates with ...e5 and piece activity. White may obtain the bishop pair or a strong center, but cannot ignore tactical pins.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black uses ...Bg4, ...e5 and sometimes ...dxc4. A bishop capture on f3 can alter your pawn structure before you castle.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the f1 bishop and secure the king according to the open lines. The central pawns can restrict the knights, but must remain supported.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.